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Tech Review 2004

A look at the year gone past, highlighting five of the biggest trends, the best technologies, the largest IT-shaking events, and the most influential people

Ahmed Shaikh

TREND > CONVERGENCE OF CELL PHONES, PDAs AND CAMERAS

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The All Conquering Cell Phone

The idea of a single electronic device which can handle sundry tasks is very attractive. The negatives of such a "convergent" device aside, the concept has taken roots and devices are sprouting left and right. The biggest showing is in

the cell phone space. The past year has seen models which bring together the functionality of three separate devices: cell phones, cameras and PDAs. Successful devices from all major vendors were launched in 2004.

The PalmOne Treo 600, in particular is very well received hardware, intelligently integrating PDA and phone functionality in a "phone-like" form-factor, complete with a QWERTY thumbboard and built-in camera. (See our review of the Treo 600 on page 75)

The 600 is the augur of better devices. Take the Sony Ericsson S700i. Out in late 2004, the phone has a 1.3 MP CCD camera and a 2.3-inch, 18-bit TFT screen. The camera is the soul of this device, so much so that the S700i has been designed to look like a camera upon glance. Its 1.3 MP hardware is essentially a Sony

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